

protean /'Prō_tē_ən/ (1) Displaying great versatility or variety. (2) Able to take on many different forms or natures.

- A protean athlete, he left college with offers from the professional leagues to play baseball, football, and basketball.

As the story is told in the *Odyssey*, at the end of the Trojan War the sea god Proteus revealed to King Menelaus of Sparta how to get home from Troy with his unfaithful wife, the beautiful Helen of Troy. Before Proteus would give up the information, though, Menelaus had to capture him—no mean feat, since Proteus had the ability to change into any natural shape he chose. The word *protean* came to describe this ability to change into many different shapes or to play many different roles in quick succession.

sibyl /'si.bəl/ A female prophet or fortune-teller.

- The villagers told him about an aged woman who lived alone in a hut on a nearby mountain, a sibyl who knew the future and would prophesy under the right conditions.

Ancient writers refer to the existence of various women in such countries as Babylonia, Greece, Italy, and Egypt, through whom the gods regularly spoke. These sibyls were easy to confuse with the oracles, women who were likewise mouthpieces of the gods, at such sites as Apollo's temple at Delphi. The most famous sibyl was the Sibyl of Cumae in Italy, a withered crone who lived in a cave. Her prophecies were collected into twelve books, three of which survived to be consulted by the Romans in times of national emergencies. She is one of the five sibyls memorably depicted by Michelangelo on the ceiling of the Sistine Chapel.

siren /'sɪrən/ A woman who tempts men with bewitching sweetness.

- Reporters treated her like a sex symbol, but she lacked the graceful presence and air of mystery of a real siren.

The sirens were a group of partly human female creatures that lured sailors onto destructive rocks with their singing. Odysseus and his men encountered the sirens on their long journey home from Troy. The only way to sail by them safely was to make oneself deaf to their enchanting song, so Odysseus packed the men's ears with wax, while he himself, ever curious, kept his ears open but had himself tied to the mast to keep from flinging himself into the water or steering his ship toward sure destruction in his desire to see them. A siren today is a sinister but almost irresistible woman. A *siren song*, however, may be any appeal that lures a person to act against his or her better judgment.

Quiz 4-5

Fill in each blank with the correct letter:

- a. odyssey
- b. calypso
- c. Penelope
- d. palladium
- e. sibyl
- f. procrustean
- g. siren
- h. protean

1. They danced and sang to the rhythm of the ____ music long into the night.
2. While he was away on maneuvers, his wife stayed loyally at home like a true ____.
3. Critics condemn modern education as ____, forcing all students into narrow and limited modes of thinking.
4. On their four-month ____ they visited most of the major cities of Asia.
5. The wedding rings were white gold, a mixture of gold and ____.
6. She won her reputation as the office ____ after her third successful prediction of who would get married next.
7. Actors like Robin Williams seem ____ in their ability to assume different characters.
8. She was a ____ of the screen in the 1920s, luring men to their doom in movie after movie.

[Answers](#)